



Protocol Report

Bitcoin, Ethereum and Solana

October 2026



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About the report

Sygnum's Protocol Report is a monthly publication providing investors and digital asset users with a data-driven view of on-chain and market activity across Bitcoin, Ethereum and Solana, as well as their respective ecosystems.

This first edition covered core metrics over longer time horizons to establish a core baseline, with subsequent editions focusing on monthly changes in protocol utility, traction and indicators that shape market sentiment, volume and demand for the asset class.

For more information on the report, or if you are interested in exploring other on-chain metrics for these assets, please reach out to asset-management@sygnum.com or research@sygnum.com.

Core market views

September delivered the cluster of connected, event-dependent risks we had flagged, and most resolved on the constructive side. Three developments landed within 48 hours in mid-month. The CLARITY Act failed its Senate cloture vote on 15 September, with the sticking point being ethics language on officials' crypto holdings. The SEC and CFTC will continue providing clarity through rulemaking and exemptions, but only within their existing statutory authority. The Federal Reserve then raised rates by a quarter point to 3.75-4.00% on 16 September, its first hike since July 2023. The following day, the SEC issued its five-year "Innovation Exemption" for tokenised stocks, filling part of the gap left by the stalled legislation through agency action.

The oil risk we flagged as the clearest threat to the constructive case eased over the month. Brent spiked toward ~USD 128 in mid-September on a Saudi supply disruption, but the move proved short-lived as exports normalised, with Brent falling back below USD 105 and ending the month near USD 97

(WTI ~USD 90). The feared persistent inflation shock did not materialise, though prices remain well above year-ago levels and the supply picture stays fragile.

Crucially, bad news largely stopped producing lower prices. Bitcoin dipped below USD 76k around the failed vote and the Fed hike, then recovered to a September peak near USD 87k, holding its gains through a rate hike and cycle-high long-end yields rather than falling with them. This resilience is the central signal. A high-beta risk asset typically weakens when policy tightens and yields climb, whereas Bitcoin held firm, broadly consistent with store-of-value behaviour. The cross-asset correlations that built through the summer support this read on a trend basis, even as they eased from their August peaks during the month.

Through the summer Bitcoin's correlation with gold rose toward its highest since 2023, its dollar correlation turned more negative, and its link to the term-premium proxy strengthened, while its equity correlation fell. These debasement-aligned signals peaked in late August, around Fed Chair Warsh's

hawkish Jackson Hole address, and eased through September even as Bitcoin held its gains. Several independent macro signals moving together through the summer is more telling than any one alone, and the combination remains broadly consistent with demand for Bitcoin as a scarce, non-sovereign store of value rather than a risk-on trade.

Ethereum and Solana took a back seat this month, with on-chain activity cooling as the Robinhood Chain surge that drove the summer faded. Both chains tracked the broader rally rather than leading it, and neither produced a marquee protocol or ecosystem catalyst. The month's story was macro and flows, not usage.

Solana was the relative standout. It posted its strongest spot-ETF inflow month since launch and extended a multi-week inflow streak, while tokenised RWA value on the network reached a new high. Ethereum was quieter, holding its position as the largest settlement layer for stablecoins and tokenised assets without a notable on-chain development.

Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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September delivered monthly gains across the majors despite a Fed hike and a failed CLARITY vote, extending the recovery and narrowing year-to-date losses

State of the market

- September extended the recovery for a second consecutive month, with all three majors posting gains despite a cluster of events that would typically weigh on risk assets: the CLARITY Act's failed Senate vote on 15 September, the Fed's first rate hike since 2023 on 16 September, and a mid-month oil spike. SOL led at roughly +15% on the month, followed by ETH at about +9% and BTC at approximately +7%, closing the month near USD 83,556, USD 2,683 and USD 118 respectively.
- The month followed a V-shape rather than a straight climb. Bitcoin dipped below USD 76,000 around the failed vote and the rate hike, then rebounded to a September peak near USD87,400 on 21 September before easing into month-end. The pattern underscores that bad news stopped producing sustained lower prices, a constructive shift in market behaviour.



Source: CoinMarketCap API. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk. *Performance since January, 2026

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Bitcoin posted a positive September and held its post-rally gains even as long-end yields climbed, reinforcing the store-of-value read

Bitcoin

On-chain activity

- Bitcoin closed September near USD 83,556, up roughly 7% on the month, holding the bulk of its August rally rather than retracing it. The gain stands out because September is historically Bitcoin's weakest month, with negative closes in eight of the prior thirteen years, and the resilience was broadly consistent with the store-of-value read discussed in the core market view rather than a conventional risk-on move.
- The month tested the store-of-value thesis directly. Bitcoin advanced even as the US 10-year yield rose about 0.5 point to 5.29% and the 30-year reached 5.63%, and the Fed delivered its first hike since 2023. Rather than trading as a long-duration risk asset hurt by higher yields, Bitcoin held firm, broadly consistent with its still-elevated gold correlation and its equity correlation remaining below early-year levels, though both eased over the month.

Newsflow

- US spot Bitcoin ETF flows followed a sharp V-shape around the mid-month events, with roughly USD 746M of outflows across 15-16 September as the CLARITY vote failed and the Fed hiked, reversing to approximately USD 2.65B of inflows over the subsequent five sessions through 23 September. The single largest day was about USD 999M on 21 September, underscoring that institutional demand returned quickly once the event risk cleared.

Bitcoin price



Source: CoinMarketCap API. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk. *Bitcoin price data as of 30.09.2026

Correlation shifts remain consistent with debasement-hedge demand, though signals eased from August peaks

Bitcoin

Gold and Dollar

- Bitcoin's 60-day correlation with gold stayed elevated at approximately +0.50, having peaked near +0.64 in late August before easing. Its dollar correlation remained negative at roughly -0.38 but also moderated from its late-August low. The relationships appear broadly consistent with demand linked to Bitcoin's scarce, non-sovereign characteristics rather than a pure risk-on trade, though the signals softened rather than strengthened over the month.

Yields and term premium

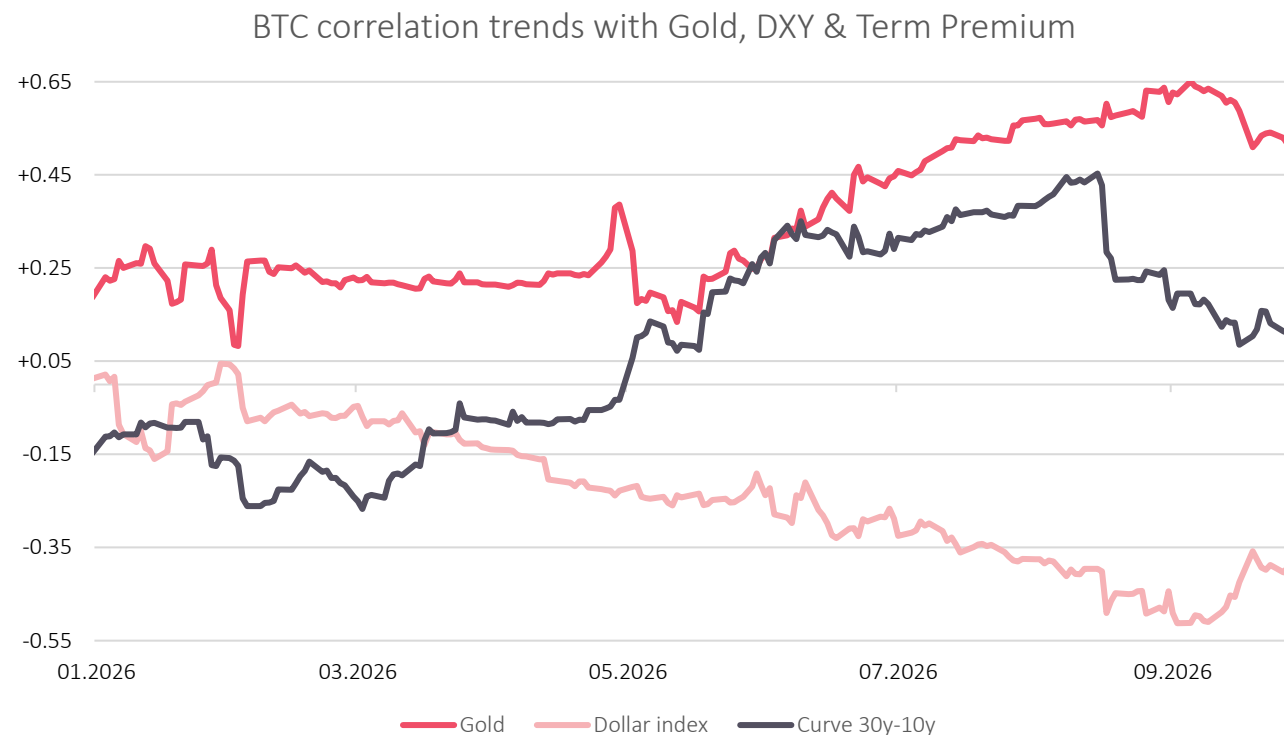
- Bitcoin advanced despite a rising-rate backdrop, with the 10-year yield near 5.29% and the 30-year around 5.63% and the Fed's first hike since 2023. That is broadly consistent with the view that Bitcoin may benefit when higher long-end yields reflect fiscal rather than growth concerns. The term-premium correlation nonetheless faded materially, from a peak near +0.45 in early August toward +0.10 by late September.

Interpretation

- The signals peaked in late August and eased through September, broadly coinciding with a more hawkish Fed posture, Chair Warsh's Jackson Hole remarks and rising September hike expectations, that appeared to temper the easing narrative behind the debasement trade. The trend remains broadly constructive, but correlations are time-varying and these shifts are consistent with a debasement read rather than proof of a durable regime change.

Source: BBG, FRED. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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Bitcoin's equity correlation fell mid-month but rebounded, leaving diversification benefits regime-dependent

Bitcoin

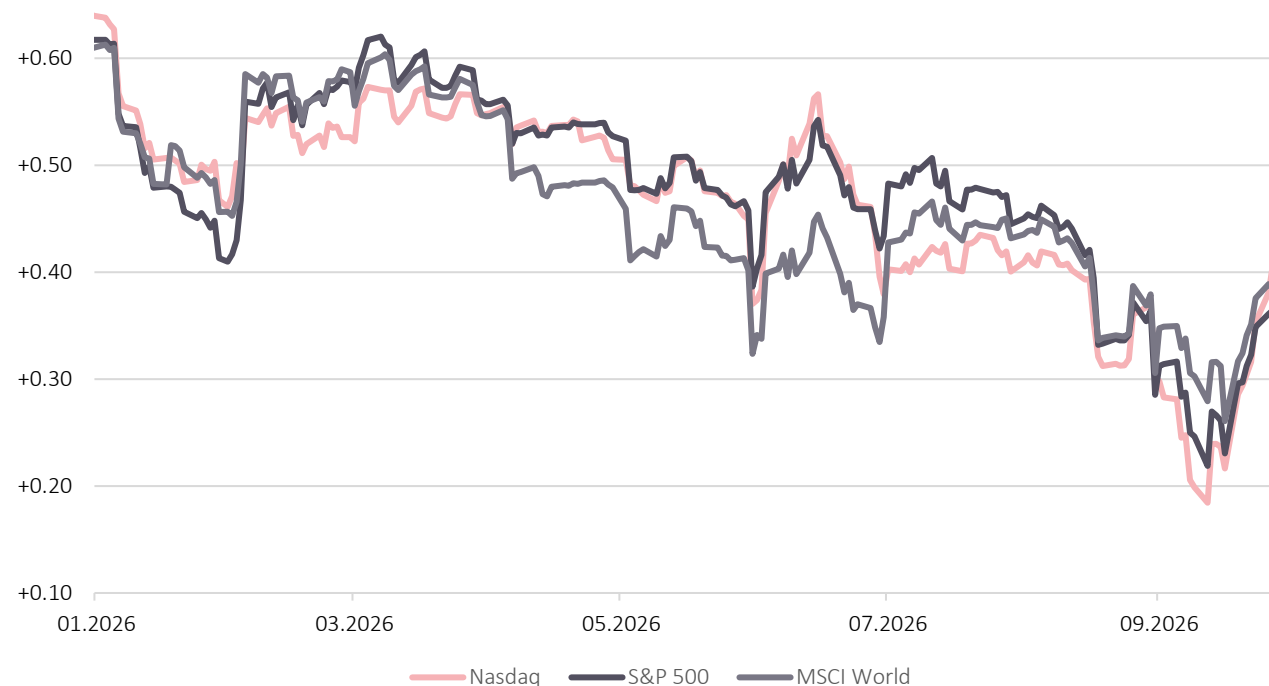
Equity correlation

- Bitcoin's 60-day correlation with major equity indices fell to a 2026 low near +0.19 in mid-September, briefly its weakest of the year, before rebounding to roughly +0.38 by month-end. The mid-month trough coincided with the stronger gold correlation and more negative dollar relationship, broadly consistent with demand beyond the conventional risk-on channel, though the late-month recovery shows how quickly the relationship can reverse.

Portfolio Implication

- Lower correlations can improve Bitcoin's diversification characteristics at the margin, but the relationships remain positive and tend to rise again during broad market stress, as the month-end rebound illustrated. Where lower correlation is accompanied by lower volatility, Bitcoin's marginal contribution to portfolio risk may fall, which in a mean-variance or risk-budget framework could in principle support a somewhat larger allocation. Any such benefit appears real but regime-dependent.

60d rolling correlation BTC vs Equity indices



Source: BBG, FRED. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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Institutional demand held through a volatile September, swinging from mid-month outflows to a 2026-record inflow week

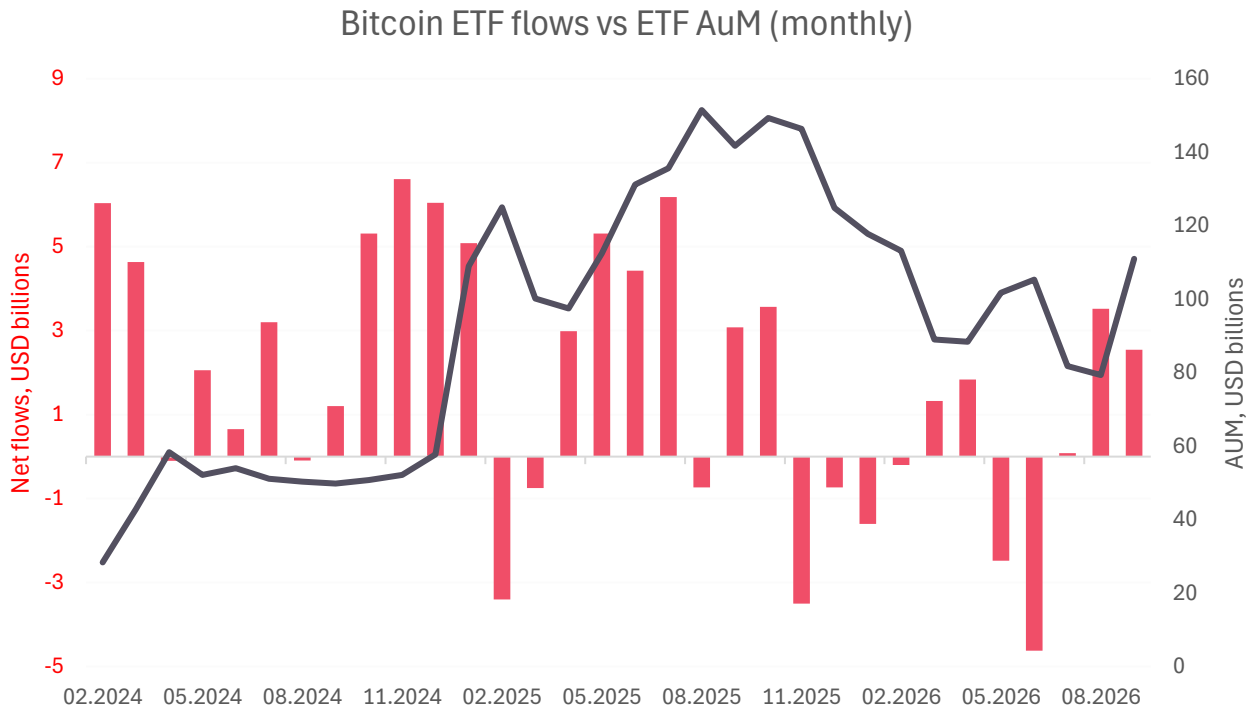


Net flows

- US spot Bitcoin ETF flows were far choppier in September than in August but ended the month net positive. Demand was strong early, turned sharply negative around the mid-month events, then rebounded to the largest weekly inflow of 2026. The pattern tracked the macro calendar almost exactly, confirming that ETF flows have become a real-time gauge of institutional risk appetite around policy events.

Bitcoin ETF AuM

- Issuer AuM recovered alongside September rally and the record inflow week, standing near USD 110B at month-end, up from USD 79B through reached during the mid-month sell-off. BlackRock's IBIT remained the dominant product at about USD 67B in net assets.



Source: CoinMarketCap API, SoSoValue. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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Ethereum held its settlement-layer role in a quiet month defined by price and flows



On-chain activity

- Ethereum's September was shaped by price and flows rather than a standout on-chain development. ETH closed the month up 9%, holding the bulk of its recovery from the June lows and reclaiming levels last seen before the summer sell-off, even as it absorbed the mid-month Fed hike and failed CLARITY vote.
- Ethereum retained its position as the largest settlement layer for on-chain dollars and tokenised assets. Tokenised RWA value plateaued over the month rather than extending its earlier climb, but the number of RWA holders continued to rise, indicating that participation kept broadening even as total value held steady. Stablecoin supply remained near historically elevated levels despite some normalisation from its late-2025 peak.

Newsflow

- Circle launched Arc, a USDC-native Layer 1 built for stablecoin settlement, with institutional validators including BlackRock, Visa and Mastercard. Arc does not displace Ethereum today, where most USDC still resides, but it reflects a broader move by issuers toward dedicated payment rails, a trend worth watching for Ethereum's settlement franchise.

Ethereum price



Source: CoinMarketCap API. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk. *Ethereum price data as of 30.09.2026

Ethereum stablecoin supply has normalised from its peak as redemptions and yield cuts unwind excess



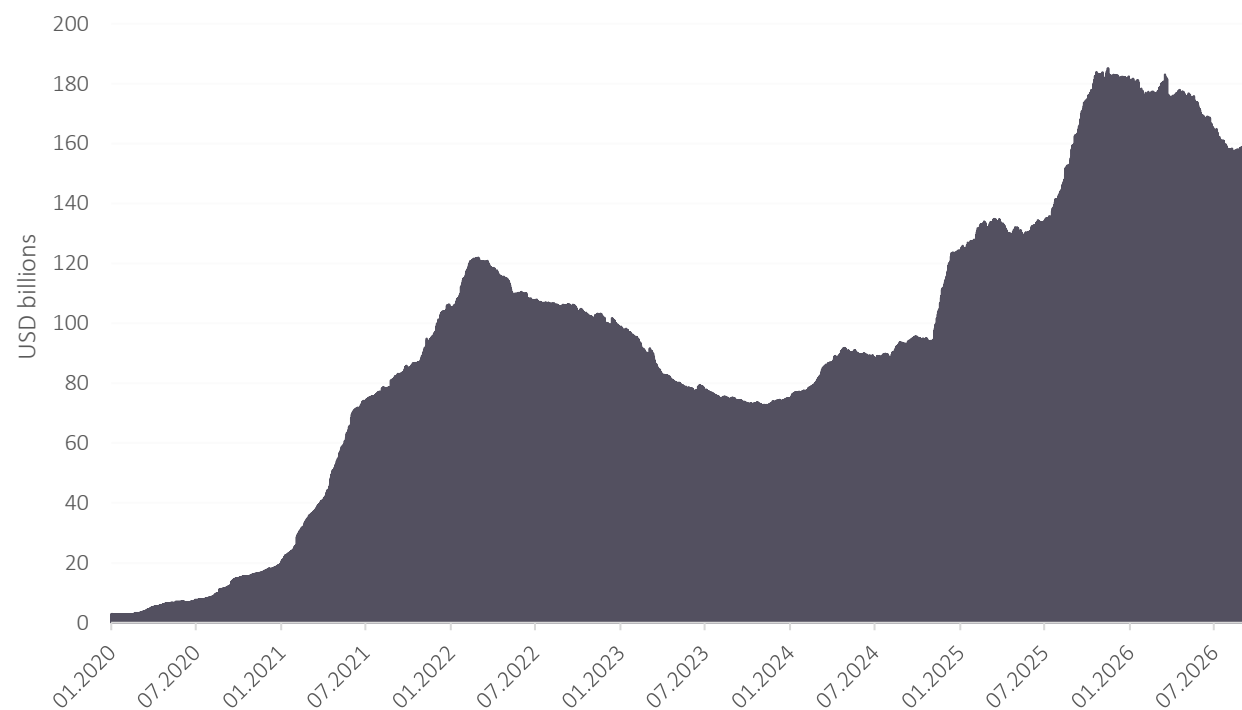
On-chain activity

- Ethereum stablecoin supply has declined from its late-2025/early-2026 high but remains near historically elevated levels, with Ethereum still hosting roughly half of all global stablecoin supply and retaining its position as the largest settlement layer for on-chain dollars.
- The contraction is a genuine unwind rather than a price effect. Because stablecoins are burned when redeemed, falling supply reflects dollars actually leaving the chain for bank deposits, consistent with a risk-off phase in which holders redeem to fiat rather than hold balances on-chain. The sharpest part of the decline, however, traced to cuts in on-chain yields on yield-bearing stablecoins rather than to lost confidence, a mechanism that can reverse quickly if yields recover or rates ease.

Qualitative factors

- The competitive backdrop intensified in September with Circle's launch of Arc, a USDC-native Layer 1 for stablecoin settlement that uses USDC as its gas token and launched with institutional validators including BlackRock, Visa and Mastercard. Arc does not displace Ethereum today, where most USDC still resides, but it echoes the migration visible in the supply data, with issuers increasingly building dedicated payment rails. The open question is whether stablecoin settlement stays concentrated on Ethereum and its Layer 2s or fragments across purpose-built chains.

Ethereum stablecoin supply



Source: Messari. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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Solana set consecutive transaction records and governance accelerated future disinflation



On-chain activity

- SOL was the strongest-performing major in September, closing near USD 118, back above USD 100 for the first time since January and well off its June low. The move was driven by institutional flows rather than on-chain speculation, with ETF demand and tokenised-asset growth the defining features of the month.
- US spot Solana ETFs recorded their strongest month since launch, drawing their largest-ever weekly inflow of approximately USD 188M in the week of 21-25 September and extending an inflow streak to twelve consecutive weeks.
- Tokenised real-world asset value on the network reached a new all-time high of approximately USD 4.5B, up from around USD 4B at end-August. By holder count the base is dominated by tokenised equities, led by tokenised NVIDIA and an S&P 500 product, while by value it is more diverse, spanning tokenised private credit, gold, and alternative assets such as tokenised reinsurance.

Solana price

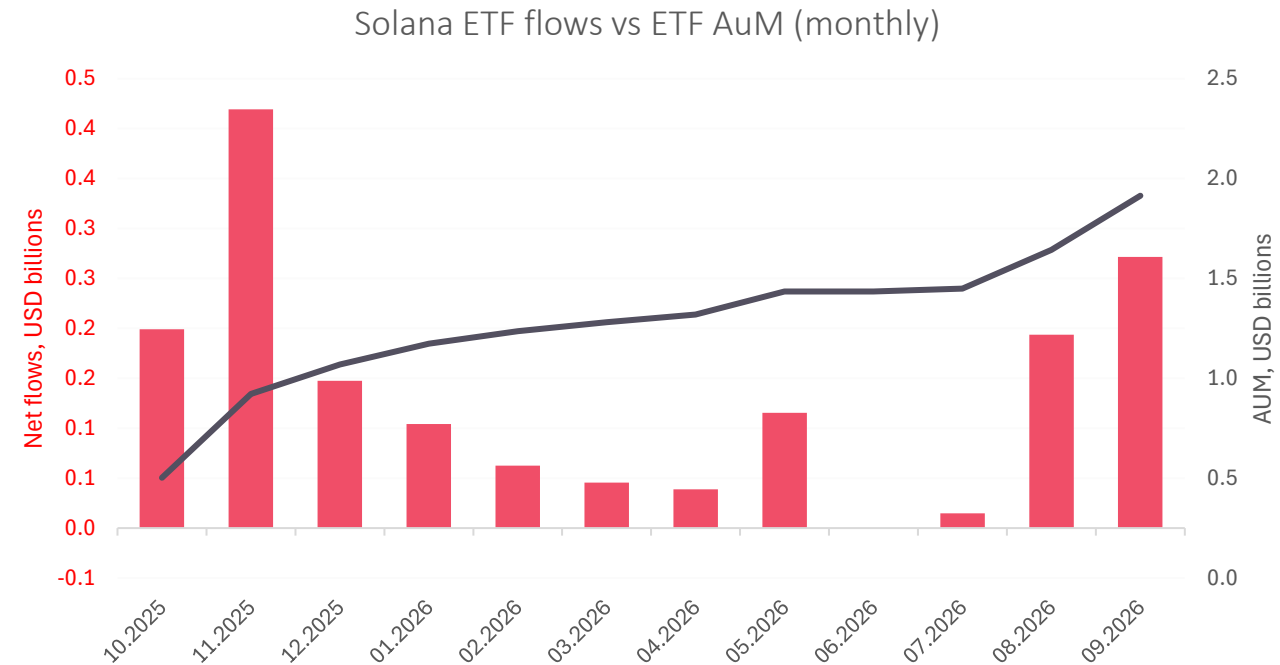


Source: CoinMarketCap API. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk. *Solana price data as of 30.09.2026

Solana ETF demand hit a record in September, extending an inflow streak that ran even as Bitcoin funds stalled



- US spot Solana ETFs recorded their strongest week since launch in September, drawing approximately USD 188M of net inflows over the five sessions of 21-25 September. This capped a 12th consecutive week of net inflows, a streak that held through mid-month even as spot Bitcoin ETFs posted their quietest week on record.
- The surge was front-loaded into a single session: roughly USD 86.7M came in on 25 September, the largest single-day inflow since the products launched. Bitwise's BSOL continued to dominate the category, accounting for the bulk of both the week's flows and cumulative inflows since inception.
- Cumulative net inflows since the October 2025 launch reached approximately USD 1.6B by month-end, with total net assets of roughly USD 1.9B, equivalent to about 2.8% of SOL's market capitalisation.



Source: CoinMarketCap API, SoSoValue. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

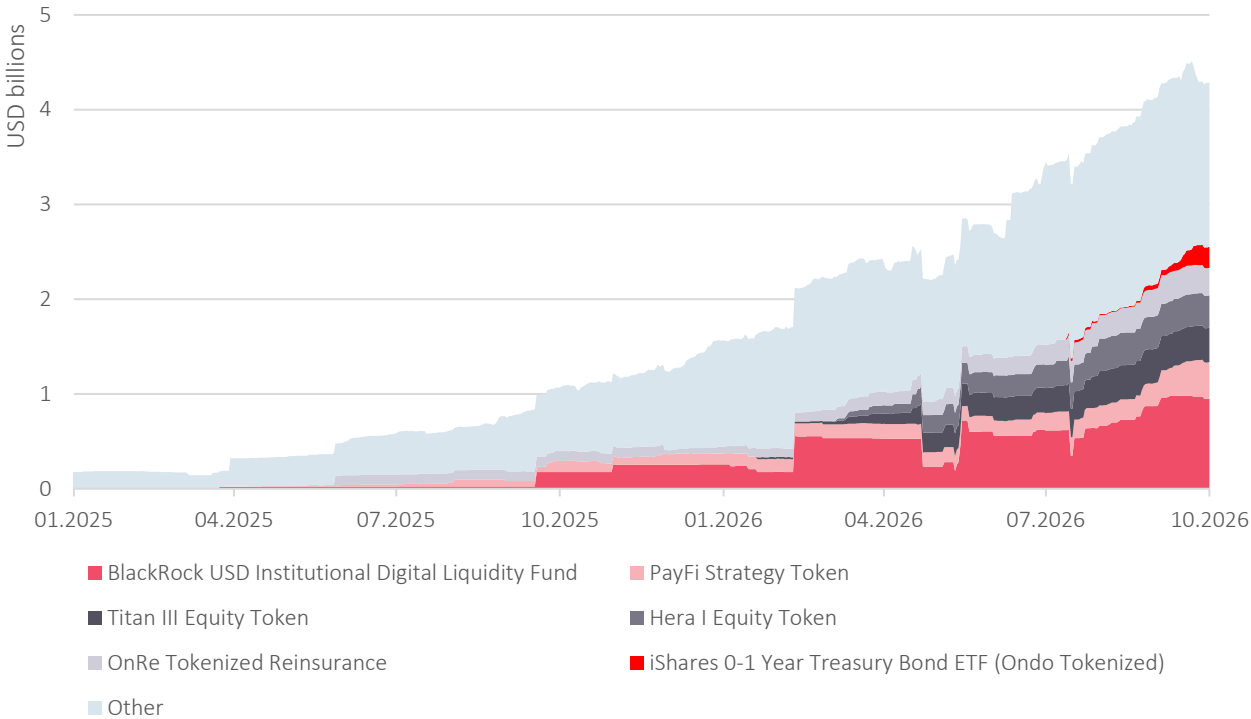
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Solana's tokenised RWA base hit a new high as Treasury and institutional products scaled



- Tokenised real-world asset value on Solana reached a new all-time high in September, with total value climbing to USD 4.5B, up from around USD 4B at the end of August and roughly USD 3.4B in June.
- By holders, tokenised equities dominate the Solana RWA base, led by tokenised NVIDIA and an S&P 500 product. By value, the base is more diverse, spanning tokenised private credit, tokenised gold, and alternative assets such as OnRe's tokenised reinsurance, which channels on-chain capital into Bermuda-based reinsurance premiums and has become one of Solana's largest RWAs by DeFi TVL.
- The pattern distinguishes Solana from Ethereum. Solana's equity tokens are attracting broad retail participation, giving it the wider holder base, while Ethereum's RWA value stays anchored in larger tokenised gold, staked-dollar and institutional yield products. Solana is building breadth in tokenised stock exposure, which aligns with the SEC's Innovation Exemption opening a conditional path for on-chain equity trading, even as its total RWA value stays well below Ethereum's.

Ethereum RWA value by product



Source: RWA.xyz. Please note that past performance is no guarantee for future performance. Capital is at risk.

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Market outlook

US digital asset regulation shifted from Congress to the agencies in September. The CLARITY Act failed its Senate cloture vote on 15 September and is effectively stalled for 2026, with the sticking point being ethics provisions on officials' crypto holdings rather than the market-structure framework itself. In its place, agency action is now the live channel. The SEC's "Regulation Crypto Assets" proposal remains open for comment into October, and the agency issued its Innovation Exemption for on-chain tokenised equities on 17 September. Agency rulemaking can advance clarity in the near term, but durable, codified market structure now likely waits for the post-election period or the next Congress.

On stablecoins, the OCC is targeting November to finalise its GENIUS Act rules, ahead of the Act's 18 January 2027 effective date, with the Federal

Reserve and Treasury proposals also advancing. The final framework is expected to address reserve, capital, custody and yield rules and clarify which issuers can serve US customers, and could prove one of the more consequential developments for the stablecoin sector, with potential read-through to the Ethereum and Solana settlement thesis.

On monetary policy, the Fed is now in a hiking cycle rather than a cutting one, a meaningful regime change. Having hiked in September, the dot plot signaled at least one more increase this year, with most participants expecting it. After softer August inflation data, markets as of early October now favor a hold at the 28 October meeting, with roughly a 76% probability rates stay at 3.75–4.00%, while pricing a hike at the 9 December meeting, where only around 19% expect

the current range to hold. By year-end the market implies a cumulative probability of about 81% for at least one further hike. The path of long-end yields and the dollar around those meetings will remain a primary driver of digital asset risk appetite.

The 3 November midterms are another catalyst, carrying implications both for the Fed's near-term caution and for the prospects of reviving crypto legislation in a lame-duck session.

On the protocol side, an eventual mainnet date for Ethereum's Glamsterdam upgrade and continued progress on Solana's Alpenglow testnet are the key network milestones to track.

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About Sygnum

Sygnum is a global digital asset banking group, founded on Swiss and Singapore heritage. We empower professional and institutional investors, banks, corporates and DLT foundations to invest in digital assets with complete trust. Our team enables this through our institutional-grade security, expert personal service and portfolio of regulated digital asset banking, asset management, tokenization and B2B services.

In Switzerland, Sygnum holds a banking licence and has CMS and Major Payment Institution licences in Singapore. The group is also regulated in the established global financial hubs of Abu Dhabi, Luxembourg and is registered in Liechtenstein.

We believe that the future has heritage. Our crypto-native team of banking, investment and digital asset technology professionals are building a trusted

gateway between the traditional and digital asset economies that we call Future Finance. To learn more about how Sygnum's mission and values are shaping this digital asset ecosystem, please visit www.sygnum.com.



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